Google Sheets as a Database

free, and your team already knows it

Google Sheets

Shop data

Order	Customer	Total	Status
ORD-1042	CUS-0001	₹2,450	Paid
ORD-1043	CUS-0003	₹980	Packed
ORD-1044	CUS-0002	₹5,100	New
ORD-1045	CUS-0004	₹12,600	Paid

Orders | Customers | Products

Swipe →

Step 1

One Tab per Thing

Customers, Orders, Products. **One row = one record**, headers in row 1.

Google Sheets

Shop data

ID	Name	Phone	City
CUS-0001	Priya Shah	+91 98xxx	Pune
CUS-0002	Rahul Mehta	+91 99xxx	Mumbai
CUS-0003	Anjali Rao	+91 97xxx	Bengaluru
CUS-0004	Sharma Traders	+91 96xxx	Delhi

Customers | Orders | Products

no merged cells. ever.

Step 2

Give Every Row an ID

A unique ID lets n8n find and update **the right row**, every time.

Google Sheets

Shop data

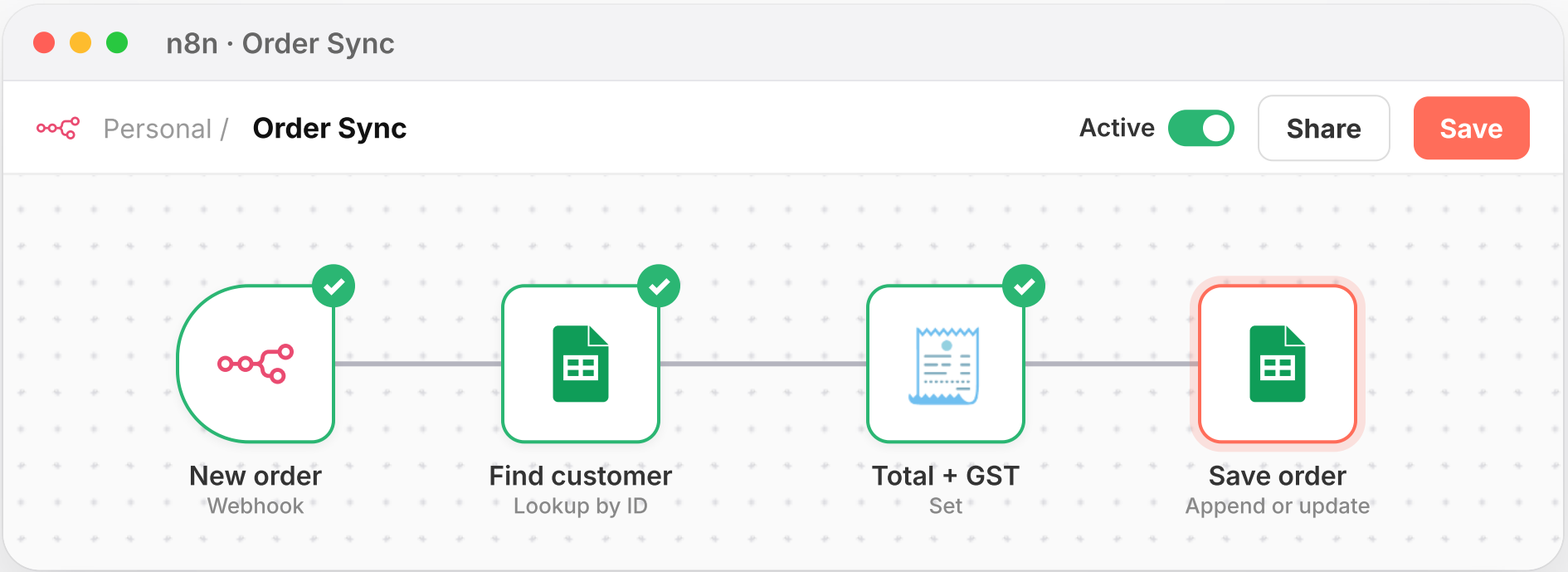
ID	Name	Phone	City
CUS-0001	Priya Shah	+91 98xxx	Pune
CUS-0002	Rahul Mehta	+91 99xxx	Mumbai
CUS-0003	Anjali Rao	+91 97xxx	Bengaluru
CUS-0004	Sharma Traders	+91 96xxx	Delhi

Customers | Orders | Products

names change. IDs don't.

Step 3

Read + Update From n8n



Google Sheets · Append or Update Row

Sheet

Orders

Column to match on

order_id

match on ID = no duplicates

Step 4

Lock Down Access

Only the workflow writes. People **read**. Fewer "who changed this?" moments.

Share "Shop data"

K	**Kishan (you)** owner	Owner ▾
n8n	**n8n service account** sync@makani-tech.iam...	Editor ▾
T	**Shop team** team@...	Viewer ▾

🔒 **Protected range:** Orders!A:F, only the service account can edit

one writer, many readers

Step 5

Know When to Move

Sheets is a great start. These are the signs **you've outgrown it**.

- ⚠️ Two workflows write at the same time
- ⚠️ You need links: orders ↔ customers
- ⚠️ It gets slow or hits API limits
- ⚠️ Private data needs real access control

Move to → **Airtable** **Supabase** **Postgres**

move when it hurts, not before

Is your Google Sheet secretly a database?

MT

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in your network

🔖

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🔔

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